
Gendered Knowledge Production in Romantic Correspondence Networks

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Abstract

As historically produced artifacts, historical sources are shaped by perspective and archival infrastructures rather than existing as "raw" data (Gitelman 2013). Source criticism is therefore a fundamental historical method. Applying it to quantitative approaches poses specific challenges and risk digital analyses to reproduce and reinforce existing biases. Since history can be understood as the "production of evidence-based arguments" (Fickers 2021, 302), it is crucial to ensure that arguments are not grounded in unbalanced sources.

We address these challenges through a case study: the correspondence network of Early German Romanticism around 1800, who left an extensive corpus of 6,175 letters. The DFG-funded project Correspondences of Early German Romanticism is the first to systematically collect and analyze this dispersed and heterogeneous material.

Among other annotations, we record which letter writers mention which works. This enables us to trace the circulation of literary ideas as a form of knowledge production. However, these processes are documented in sources shaped by gendered power structures. Women of the Romantic Circle were underrepresented due both to constraints of the period and to patriarchal archival practices (Wernli 2022). We therefore ask: How can the impact that women had on knowledge production be made visible through network analysis?

To address this problem, we combine network analysis with the theoretical framework of Data Feminism (D'Ignazio und Klein 2020). Our analysis is based on a two-mode network modeling relationships between persons and works mentioned in letters. First, we add a layer of source criticism by contextualizing gendered biases in the corpus, and then revise the network to highlight female authorship and correspondence.

This approach yields three key results: (1) following the principle "Examine Power" (D'Ignazio und Klein 2020, 21), we reveal a pronounced gender data gap (Criado-Perez 2020) (2) focusing on female correspondents highlights overlooked forms of knowledge production; (3) even without altering the network structure, contextualized analysis makes women's influence visible.

References

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